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Probing the impact of transformational leadership on job embeddedness: the moderating role of job characteristics

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Abstract

Purpose – This paper aims to evaluate how transformational leadership can increase job embeddedness in their employees that persuade them to stay in their organization and how this relationship is contingent upon the job characteristics.

Design/methodology/approach – Sample of 328 useable responses was available for analysis. Questionnaires were distributed to the employees who are working in different Pakistani organizations. Regression analysis was used to test for hypotheses.

Findings – The findings support that there is a significant impact of transformational leadership for shaping job embeddedness, and the results endorsed the role of job characteristics as a moderator in describing the relationship of transformational leadership and job embeddedness. Transformational leaders would motivate employees to work together in productive manners in challenging work settings.

Originality/value – This paper makes three key contributions to the literature on job design. First, this inquiry shows that a strong link does exist between transformational leadership in creating organizational job embeddedness. Second, it highlights how job characteristics of highly challenging work settings may shape employees' job embeddedness. Third, this paper offers a novel perspective in leadership research by incorporating high challenging work setting (i.e. job characteristics) as moderator. Managers may get new insight by opting for transformational leaders' attributes and concentrating on high challenging work settings for creating embeddedness in employees to prolong their stay with the job and firm.

Keywords Transformational leadership, Job characteristics, Job embeddedness, Social exchange theory

Paper type Research paper

1. Introduction

In the current competitive environment, talent retention is crucial for organizations. The quitting of employees increases abstract and concrete costs, which reduce the firm's profitability and become the cause of loss for worthy employees (Candan, 2016). Contrariwise, the firm's abstract overheads related to the leaving of employees cause harmful effects on corporate culture, workers' self-confidence and communal capital (Tanova, 2007). Examples of concrete costs are the cost of fresh recruitment, selection, training, consolidating period and prospective service quality concerns, human capital loss and organizational activities distraction (Cunningham *et al.*, 2005).

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For the retention of talented employees, job embeddedness is found as one of the best retention strategy which may be adopted by the organizations (Crossley *et al.*, 2007; Holtom and Darabi, 2018; Park and Pierce, 2020; Yang *et al.*, 2020). Such retention strategy can also help in enhancing the performance of the workers through fit, links and sacrifice (Nafei, 2015; Yang *et al.*, 2020). Organizations are in great need of creating job embeddedness in their employees to achieve the organizational desired goals and outputs. Job satisfaction (Rust *et al.*, 1996), organizational commitment (Lee *et al.*, 1992), discretionary effort (Lloyd, 2008), intent to stay (Tett and Meyer, 1993), job engagement (Wefald and Downey, 2009), high-performance HRM practices (Tian *et al.*, 2016), work-social support (Karatepe, 2013b; Nguyen *et al.*, 2017), work-family conflict and work overload (Karatepe, 2013a) and flex work time (Chan *et al.*, 2019) are all hypothetical models established by human resource development scholars to describe and forecast employees' retention and can be considered as antecedents of organizational job embeddedness.

Some factors may also significantly be considered for increasing job embeddedness (Shehawy *et al.*, 2018), including leadership styles. Rare studies in the past found the relationship of leaders' behavior in embedding employees (Harris *et al.*, 2011; Pimonratanakan *et al.*, 2017), and the few studies found the leadership style impact for developing job embeddedness. For example, the study of Ferreira (2017) examined the effect of ethical leadership with job embeddedness, and the research of Erkutlu and Chafra (2017) resulted in the significant positive influence of empowering leadership for estimating job embeddedness.

More specifically, according to transformational leadership theory, transformational leadership style is considered as persuasive leadership style over the past two decades (Avolio *et al.*, 2009; Jam *et al.*, 2018; Judge and Piccolo, 2004), and a very strong relationship has been observed among the transformational leadership dimensions which enable the workers to build a strong identification with their leaders (Bass and Avolio, 1990). Furthermore, there is a need to explore job characteristics' role in making over the effects of leadership style on job embeddedness.

According to Rafique (2015), economically constrained research communities of developing countries require more research for their society's well-being. Pakistan is an under-developing country where organizations believe in exchanging rewards for employees instead of motivating employees. The current study explores the motivational starring role of transformational leadership in various industries of Pakistan after identifying the dire need of the organizations about the dynamic role of leaders in challenging work settings, which leads to improved bonding of employees with one another.

Drawing upon transformational leadership theory and related literature, in this paper, we tried to probe how transformational leaders enhance their employees' association with the organization. We also propose the job characteristics model of Hackman and Oldham (1975), which is considered as a moderator and proved as a critical factor that further help to enhance the ties of individuals within the organization.

2. Theoretical framework and hypotheses development

2.1 Transformational leadership and job embeddedness

Management researchers have long been identifying the reasons for employees' active role in organizations and their motivation to perform well and stay in the organization for a long time. According to March and Simon's (1958) model, dissatisfaction will ultimately reduce employees' probability of staying in the organization (Mobley, 1977). Then Mitchell *et al.* (2001) first theorized the concept of job embeddedness by focusing on the factors of individuals who stay with their organization. They claimed job embeddedness is signifying

some forces that keep employees in their current employment. Job embeddedness consists of on-the-job and off-the-job embeddedness (Mitchell *et al.*, 2001). Such types of embeddedness are represented by three underlying components (*fit, links and sacrifice*). *Fit* refers to an employee's perceived compatibility with the working environment (Mitchell *et al.*, 2001). *Links* are concerned with formal or informal ties between employees and organizations and other coworkers, while *sacrifice* refers to the ostensible cost incurred by leaving a job (Mitchell*et al.*, 2001). Employees with a higher level of job embeddedness more likely to establish a deeper social tie with their bosses and coworkers (Peachey *et al.*, 2014). According to Al-Ghazali (2020), these factors would be expected to influence employee performance positively. Employees with high-quality relations with their leaders feel better and perform their tasks effectively when they get a comfortable working environment and resource.

Job embeddedness theory argues that leaders embedding role for their employees is a significant source of inspiration (Mitchell *et al.*, 2001). Both the transformational leadership and embeddedness literature suggest that the strong linkage between them forces employees to stay, even within contexts that might push people to quit (Al-Ghazali, 2020). Transformational leaders inspire followers to anticipate the future projections of their profession based on the level of job embeddedness because strong linkages gradient people to stay and perform well (Al-Ghazali, 2020). Job embeddedness embodies a broad cluster of factors that explain employees' reasons for staying in an organization. As leaders can more readily influence on the employees' job embeddedness through these numerous factors (Eberlya *et al.*, 2017; Hairudinor *et al.*, 2017).

Transformational leadership theory postulates that such type of leadership increases followers' suitability in the organization through these embedding factors. Moreover, transformational leaders are essential for the followers, and the follower shares a personal and social identity with the leader (Al-Ghazali,2020). Cetin and Kinik (2015) further highlighted that the fundamental dimensions of the transformational leader act like as an ideal role model for the subordinates *(Idealized influence*) through the ability to inspire their followers with a sense of motivation, confidence *(Inspirational motivation),* the leader broadens and elevates the interests of his or her employees through building a strong vision in their followers based on values and ideals *(Intellectual stimulation)*, and by considering the individual follower needs *(Individual consideration)*, these four dimensions assist to employees to work together in the organization with harmony.

Transformational leaders are valued and trusted by their subordinates as they ponder the *Idealized influence* for their best concerns (Kelloway *et al.*, 2012) that create a liaison between employees and the leader. Such leaders help and facilitate their employees in creating an open environment by giving a sense of confidence to share their ideas, leading to developing interpersonal relationships among employees. Another characteristic of leaders is *inspirational motivation,* which may increase the followers' task identity, enabling them to feel confident regarding their job (Turner *et al.*, 2002). Purvanova *et al.* (2006) examined that leaders with inspirational motivation may influence subordinates' attitudes toward the jobs and surge meaning in work and penetrate in employees' a feeling of the purposeful job. *Intellectual stimulation* aspect of the leaders' triggers the motivation level of the employees to ruminate out of the box and is positively associated with the employees' creativity, which appeared in the form of subordinate's confidence as the leaders trust in the capabilities of their followers and value their contributions (Suifan *et al.*, 2018). Same likely *individual consideration* of leader shows concern for followers' needs and feelings. The leaders consider each employee individually and motivate them to acquire further job skills (Sosik *et al.*,

2004). These evidences predict that transformational leadership can enhance the employee to feel fit with their job and organization.

Hence, transformational leadership does affect perceived job embeddedness. It is hypothesized that as employees become more embedded by the presence of transformational leaders. Based on the above evidence and arguments, it is identified that transformational leaders with their distinctive characteristics may become constructing source in creating links of employees with their job. Therefore, this is being hypothesized that:

H1. Transformational leadership is positively associated with employee's job embeddedness.

2.2 Moderating impact of job characteristics in the relationship between transformational leadership and job embeddedness

The job characteristics model postulates that five core job characteristics encompass five dimensions, including skills variety, job identity, job significance, autonomy and feedback, making the jobs intrinsically motivating and satisfying and encouraging high performance (Hackman and Oldham, 1980). The Job Characteristics Model (Hackman and Oldham, 1976) strengthened the value of job enrichment that brings about positive effects on employees' attitudes and behaviors to assess the extent to which they can be motivated intrinsically (Zhao *et al.*, 2016). Job characteristics significantly impact the meaningfulness, responsibility and knowledge that employees associate with their job activities (Zhao *et al.*, 2016). These five core job characteristics would have an affirmative effect on employee job embeddedness. The five core job characteristics illustrate employees' fitness with their jobs (Ehrhart, 2006), and they consider their job meaningful. Meaningful jobs are a source of motivation for the employees (Fried and Ferris, 1987). Such motivation develops their task-related knowledge and skills (Kanfer, 1991). The knowledge and skills acquired would improve employee's performance level, and as a result, employees would better fit in their job and are more likely to stay in their enriched jobs (Orpen, 1979). Thus, job enrichment influences the employees' level of attachment with their job and organization (Griffeth, 1985). Thus, a better evaluation of job content and job context by the employees leads to a sense of obligation and commitment toward the organization (Ahmad, 2018).

Leaders can develop positive employee morale by redesigning and enriching jobs (Liu *et al.*, 2013; Sengphet *et al.*, 2019). Knowing these attributes of job characteristics theory, the leaders can use this information for work with the subordinates to ensure their job satisfaction is intact and positive that can lead them to feel embedded toward their job and organization. Transformational leaders may create meaningful work for their subordinates (Han and Oh, 2020). This meaningfulness of work toward the job leads to organizational commitment (Geldenhuys *et al.*, 2014) and job satisfaction (Duffy *et al.*, 2015). Subsequently, these favorable job characteristics are associated with the link dimension of job embeddedness and suggest that transformational leaders, by using job characteristics, can enhance employees' attachment toward their job and organization.

De Jonge and Schaufeli (1998) proposed a significant influence of job characteristics, job autonomy, job demand and workplace social support on the psychological well-being of employees; job stress, job satisfaction and emotional exhaustion. It suggests that when the employees are provided favorable job characteristics, these enhance their well-being and motivate the employees to be more linked with their job and organization, and they must sacrifice these psychological rewards when they leave the organization. This evidence suggests a significant impact of job characteristics with the sacrifice dimension of job embeddedness. Therefore, overall, it is expected that job characteristics would positively influence

organizational job embeddedness, and the managers, through the attributes of transformational leadership, use these job characteristics as a tool to embed their subordinates toward the job and organization. Hence, the current study tries to identify the moderating effect of job characteristics in the relationship between transformational leadership and organizational job embeddedness such that the enriched job characteristics may enhance the positive relationship of transformational leadership and organizational job embeddedness.

H2. Job characteristics are positively associated with employee's job embeddedness.

H3. Job characteristics moderates the relationship of transformational leadership and employee's job embeddedness such that the relationship will be strengthened with high job characteristics (Figure 1).

3. Research methodology

3.1 Sample and procedures

The sample of the present study was drawn from the personnel through a cross-sectional survey. Convenience sampling was used to collect the data. The questionnaires were distributed through email and directly to the employees working at various designations in different organizations of three sectors including education, banking and the pharmaceutical sector, to capture the maximum variation. Sample surveys were sent to 30 organizations. Out of 530 circulated questionnaires, only 380 responses were received. After eliminating the incomplete forms, 342 useable responses were available for analysis. The response rate was 72%. The collected data was 9.4% (32/342) from the banking sector, 59% (202/342) from the education sector and 31.6% (108/342) belong to the pharmaceutical sector. In Table A1 in the Appendix, demographic details are provided.

3.2 Measures

Table 1 demonstrates the study's constructs, items, overall reliability estimates, Cronbach's alphas, composite reliabilities (CR) and average variance extracted (AVE).

3.2.1 Transformational leadership. TL was assessed by using a 20-items scale from MLQ (Antonakis *et al.*, 2003), including five subsections; IDI (attributed and behavior), IM, IC and IS consisting of four items for each subdivision. Questionnaire items were graded on

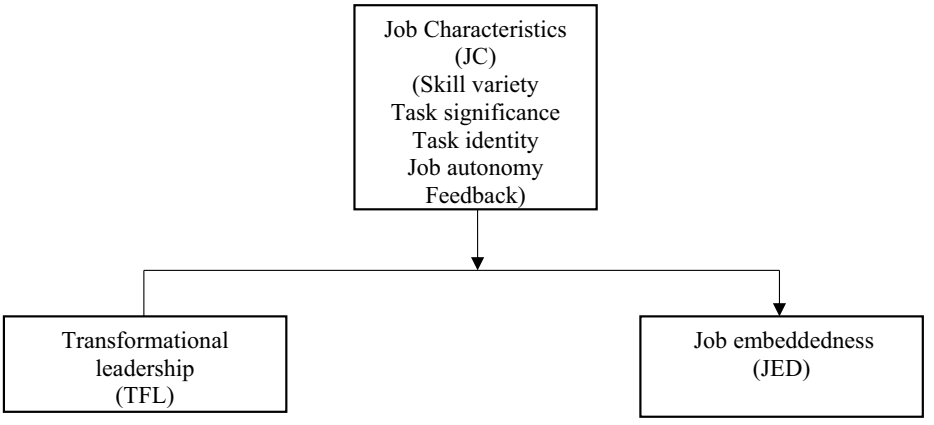


Figure 1.
A theoretical model of the study

Items	Factor loadings
Transformational leadership (α = 0.973, CR = 0.972, AVE = 0.642)	
My manager\employer instils pride in me for being associated with him/her	0.821
He\She goes beyond self-interest for the good of the group	0.791
He\She acts in ways that build my respect	0.784
He\She displays a sense of power and confidence	0.796
He\She provides complete trust	0.838
He\She talks about his/her most important values and beliefs	0.816
He\She specifies the importance of having a strong sense of purpose	0.796
He\She considers the moral and ethical consequences of decisions	0.743
He\She emphasizes the importance of having a collective sense of mission	0.803
He\She talks optimistically about the future	0.875
He\She talks enthusiastically about what needs to be accomplished	0.754
He\She articulates a compelling vision of the future	0.79
He\She expresses confidence that goals will be achieved	0.823
He\She spends time teaching and coaching	0.852
He\She treats me as an individual rather than just a member of the group	0.812
He\She considers me as having different needs, abilities and aspirations from others	0.757
He\She helps me to develop my strengths	0.783
He\She re-examines critical assumptions to question whether they are appropriate	0.823
He\She seeks differing perspectives when solving problems	0.814
He\She gets me to look at problems from many different angles	0.757
Job characteristics (α = 0.964, CR = 0.964, AVE = 0.602)	
How much variety is there in the job? That is, to what extent does the job require a person to do many different things at work using variety of skills and talent?	0.866
The job requires a person to use a number of complex or high-level skills	0.828
The job is quite simple and repetitive	0.751
To what extent does the job involve doing a "whole" and identifiable piece of work? That is, is the job a complete piece of work that has an obvious beginning and end? Or is it only a small part of the overall piece of work, which is finished by other people or by automatic machines?	0.802
The job provides him/her the chance to completely finish the piece of work which he/she begins	0.81
The job is arranged so that a person does not have the chance to do an entire piece of work from beginning to end	0.785
In general, how significant or important is this job? That is, are the results of the person's work likely to significantly affect the lives or well-being of other people?	0.748
This job is one where a lot of other people can be affected by how well the work gets done	0.731
The job itself is not very significant or important in broader scheme of things	0.733
How much autonomy is there in this job? That is, to what extent does the job permit a person to decide on his or her how to go about doing the work?	0.813
The job gives a person considerable opportunity for independence and freedom in how he or she does the work	0.753
The job denies a person any chance to use my personal initiative or judgment in carrying out my work	0.729
To what extent does doing the job itself provide the person information about his or her work performance? That is, does the actual work itself provide clues	0.846

(*continued*)

Table 1.
Constructs and measurement items

Items	Factor loadings
about how well the person is doing-aside from any "feedback" co-workers or supervisors may provide?	
Just doing the work required by the job provides many chances for me to figure out how well I am doing	0.789
The job itself provides very few clues about whether or not I am performing well	0.775
To what extent do managers or co-workers let you know how well you are doing on your job?	0.771
Supervisor often let the person know how well they think he or she is performing the job	0.748
The supervisors and co-workers on this job almost never give a person any "feedback" about how well he or she is doing work?	0.667
Job embeddedness ($\alpha = 0.925$, CR = 0.925, AVE = 0.579)	
My job uses my skills and talents well	0.803
I feel like I am a good match for my organization	0.827
If I stay with my organization, I will be able to achieve most of my goals	0.769
I have a lot of freedom on this job to pursue my goals	0.731
I would sacrifice a lot if I left this job	0.707
I believe the prospects for continuing employment with my organization are excellent	0.758
I am a member of an effective work group	0.777
I work closely with my coworkers	0.792
On the job, I interact frequently with my work group members	0.674

Notes: Data Source 2: Provided by authors, Abbreviations: CR (composite reliabilities), AVE (average variance extracted)

Table 1.

a five-point Likert scale, ranging from one to five; 1 (never) to 5 (frequently, not if always). Following are some exemplary items: "Acts in ways that build my respect," "seeks differing perspectives when solving problems." The Cronbach's alpha in the existent study was 0.97.

3.2.2 Job characteristics. Job characteristics were measured with the self-reported measures of the JDS (Hackman and Oldham, 1976). Sample items with anchors of 1= very little and 7 = very much included for all five characteristics. The reliability of overall job characteristics was 0.94.

3.2.3 Job embeddedness. JED was measured with the self-reported measure developed by Holtom and fellows in (2006). Shorten version of the existing scale with 21 items was being used. Shorten version was equally valid and effective as the original scale of 40 items, which is being used by (Felps *et al.*, 2009) in their study. Out of 21 items, 3 items were dichotomous in nature that required answers in the form of "yes" or "no" and might be considered an incursion of secrecy (Crossley *et al.*, 2007), so those items were also excluded from the analysis. And from the remaining 18 items, 9 nine items were used to measure organizational job embeddedness via a five-point Likert scale ranging from 1 = strongly disagree to 5 = strongly agree. Other nine community embeddedness items were excluded as community embeddedness is not part of our research scope. The study evaluated the value of Cronbach's alpha as 0.93.

The past studies found demographic variables such as gender and tenure as influencers of JED (Giosan, C. 2003), and they were considered as control variables. However, the current study did not find any significant correlations of demographics with the dependent and

independent variables. Thus, the present study did not take any control variables in the model.

Table 2 shows the values of means, standard deviations, correlations and reliabilities for all variables involved in the study. The intercorrelations among the variables indicate the positive relationship between TL and JED ($r = 0.640$, $p < 0.01$) and JC and JED also have a direct significant relationship ($r = 0.302$, $p < 0.01$). There was no significant correlation of demographics with the constructs.

To address common method bias, the researcher has taken the necessary steps that are ex-ante procedures to diminish the threat of CMV. The authors collected the responses for independent and dependent variables at different points in time. Moreover, the data has been collected from different organizations of three sectors to increase the generalizability and to mitigate the effect of CMV that results due to the same source of data collection. A cover letter was attached with questionnaires that explained the study's scope and guaranteed participants about the responses' strict confidentiality to encourage the respondents to answer honestly and hence reduced the effect of biased responses from the participants.

3.3 Confirmatory factor analysis

AMOS was used to run confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) to check the validity (convergent and discriminant) among all the items of the three variables involved.

Additionally, the AVE value is also above the threshold value 0.5, which suggests the scale's convergent validity (Bagozzi and Yi, 1988). Discriminant validity was also confirmed by comparing the value of AVE of each construct with the squared value of the correlation of the corresponding pair of constructs (Fornell and Larcker, 1981). One factor CFA model was analyzed and found better model fit results as written in bracket shown ($chi^2 = 2224.2$, df = 1015, $chi^2/df = 2.19$, RMSEA = 0.05, CFI = 0.914, NFI = 0.85) were on an acceptable level as the value of Chi-sq/df was 2.19 which was less than 3, the threshold value suggested by Marsh and Hocevar (1985) and the value of RMSEA was 0.05 which was also less than the cutoff 0.08 as suggested by Browne *et al.* (1993). Similarly, the CFI value was 0.914 same as the cutoff value greater than 0.90 proposed by Bentler (1990). NFI's value was also 0.85, close to the threshold value greater than 0.90 (Gefen *et al.*, 2000) that suggested for further analysis. The results of the CFA also provided evidence that the problem of common method bias and variance was assessed and controlled (Podsakoff *et al.*, 2003).

Table 2.
Means, standard deviations, correlations and reliabilities (in brackets)

Variables	Mean	SD	Industry type	Gender	TWE	WEICO	TL	JC	JED
Industry type	2.356	1.8207							
Gender	1.435	0.496	−0.065						
TWE	1.684	0.947	−0.025	−0.336**					
WEICO	1.169	0.578	−0.161**	−0.135*	0.558**				
TL	3.742	0.741	−0.097	−0.02	0.028	0.059	**(0.973)**		
JC	3.582	0.696	−0.004	0.055	−0.04	−0.087	0.063	**(0.964)**	
JED	3.808	0.586	−0.025	−0.019	0.033	0.04	**0.640****	**0.302****	**(0.925)**

Notes: Data Source 3: Provided by authors, N = 342, Abbreviations: TWE = Total working experience, WEICO = Working experience in the current organization *$p \leq 0.05$ **$p \leq 0.01$ ***$p \leq 0.001$

3.4 Regression analysis

We used regression analysis to find the linear relationship among the variables. To assess the effect of demographic variables with the dependent and independent variables, we regressed age, gender and tenure on JED but did not find any significant impact of these demographics on job embeddedness as shown in Table 4. The study used process macro by Hayes to estimate the moderating influence of job characteristics between TL and JED. The model suggested appropriate explanations of the TL and JC on the dependent variable JED as ($R^2 = 0.49$, $p < 0.01$) as shown in Table 3. This indicates the capability of the model for predicting job embeddedness through transformational leadership and job characteristics. Moreover, the moderating effect of job characteristics in the relationship between TL and JED was significant as the value of R^2 for the model increased by 1.2% with $p = 0.0043$ when the interaction effect is added. The results are shown in Table 5.

3.5 Hypotheses testing

The hypothetical relationship was evaluated through process macro model 1 that found the direct effect of TL and JC on JED and evaluated the moderation of JC in the relationship of TL and JED. In Table 5, the direct relationship of TL with JED was found significant ($\beta = 0.486$, $p < 0.01$), and *H1* was accepted. This suggested that organizational job embeddedness can be predicted through transformational leadership. The direct relationship of JC and JED was also found significant ($\beta = 0.219$, $p < 0.01$) and suggested job characteristics as a significant predictor of organizational JED and supported in the acceptance of *H2*. Moreover, the interactive effect of TL with JC ($\beta = 0.107$, $p < 0.05$) also showed an extensive impact in determining JED; thus, *H3* is also proved, which suggests that when the interactive effect was added to the model, the effect of transformational leadership in predicting JED increased. Figure 2 shows that the relationship of TL with JED was positive and high with high job characteristics. This means high job characteristics enhanced the direct effect of TL on organizational JED.

4. Discussion and conclusion

4.1 Theoretical implications

This study was proposed to predict job embeddedness through transformational leadership with the direct and moderating impact of job characteristics. The study results found that leaders may improve job embeddedness in employees through their capabilities of inspiring, motivating and stimulating the followers and considering their subordinates as an individual. In the research, we empirically established the association between TL and JED, and the study estimated the number of contributions in terms of theory. First, this research contributed in the existing theory of JED by identifying TL and JC as significant predictors of JED. Second, the findings of the study found job characteristics as a crucial moderator

						Change Statistics			
Model	*R*	*R* Square	Adjusted *R* Square	Std. error of the estimate	*R* Square Change	F Change	df1	df2	Sig. F Change
1	0.692[a]	0.479	0.471	0.42631	0.479	61.764	5	336	0.000

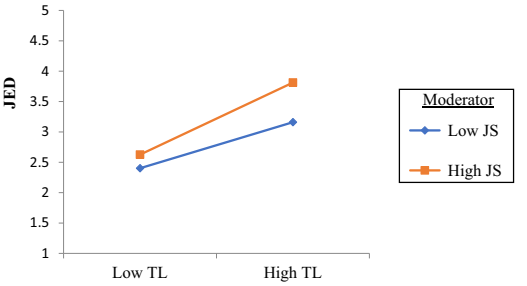
Notes: [a]Predictors: (Constant), Working Experience in Current Organization, TFL, JC, Gender, Total Working Experience

Source: Provided by authors

Table 3. Model summary

between TL and JED. The JED theory proposed by Mitchel and fellows in (2001) has been considered as a retention strategy adopted by organizations for reducing turnover intentions of employees.

The past studies investigated that employees feel more embeddedness while working under authentic (Erkutlu and Chafra, 2016) and empowering leadership (Erkutlu and Chafra, 2015). The present study empirically evaluated transformational leadership as a significant antecedent of job embeddedness. The reason for such a positive relationship is that the leaders with the attribute of individual consideration enhance the feeling of job-fit in the employees. The leaders' idealized influence builds the strong leader–follower relationships that assist them in establishing links with the teams, workers and groups. Moreover, the leader's inspirational motivation ability enables them to communicate the followers' clear vision for their future that builds a sense of link in the employees with their job, and firm



Source: Provided by authors

Figure 2.
Moderation of Job characteristicsData Source 7: Provided by authors

Model	Unstandardized coefficients B	Std. Error	Standardized coefficients Beta	T	Sig.
Gender	−0.018	0.050	−0.015	−0.355	0.723
Total working experience	0.007	0.031	0.011	0.220	0.826
Working experience in current organization	0.019	0.048	0.019	0.391	0.696

Source: Provided by authors

Table 4.
Job embeddedness

Hypotheses	Relationships	Estimates	S.E	*t*-value	*p*-value	Decision
H1	TL → JED	0.486	0.040	12.310	0.000	Supported
H2	JC → JED	0.219	0.038	5.834	0.000	Supported
H3	Int_TFLxJC → JED	0.107	0.053	2.012	0.045	Supported
	R^2 increase		*0.012*			
	F		*4.048*		0.045	

Notes: Abbreviations: TL= Transformational leadership, JED= Job embeddedness, JC= Job characteristics
Source: Provided by authors

Table 5.
Job characteristics moderation analysis

and leaders stimulate the workers to think independently that penetrates creativity among the employees. They feel more fit to the job in performing their roles to achieve the desired outcomes. Such leaders' abilities provide the employee with supportive working conditions and environment that reduce the intent of turnover among employees as aligned by the earlier studies of Shukla and Sinha (2013) suggested by social exchange theory of Blau (1964) that states, actions of the people depend on their expectations with their leaders.

The current study also contributed by estimating the moderating influence of job characteristics in the relationship between TL and JED. The results of the analysis provided favorable results. The job characteristics provided a significant contribution in determining job embeddedness and depicted evidence of significant moderating impact. The direct positive relationship of strong job characteristics provides meaningfulness to the job, enhancing the reason for a stay in the organization. Enriched job characteristics provide employees a sense of fit and link with their job and organization, leading them to stay in their jobs and organizations. Thus, according to Hackman and Oldham (1974) and Nguyen (2015), job characteristics will positively influence the organizational outcomes when the job characteristics are high, then the strength of TL and JED is enhanced in the current study. When the leaders favorably designed the job characteristics for the employees, those characteristics become a bonding force for employees that fosters employees JED.

4.2 Managerial implications

Employees with low job embeddedness display low performance, lower quality decision-making and high employee turnover rates (Lee *et al.*, 2004). Thus, this is important to concentrate on enhancing embeddedness in employees. The findings of the study showed that transformational leaders help in creating organizational embeddedness and job characteristics strengthen the positive relationship between TL and JED. The present study has important implications not only for the business enterprises and non-business enterprises but also for the electronic media channels and political parties for retaining skilled, trained, qualified and experienced workers for achieving competitive advantage. Managers should take the following steps; first, through training sessions, workshops, and seminars at each level of management, managers' may enhance the transformational leadership skills; this would be helpful in creating the three embeddedness elements in their employees. Second, the managers should promote a highly competitive work environment for enhancing the quality of a better working relationship in the organization, which ultimately promotes job embeddedness among them. Third, the effects of transformational leadership may vary depending on the context in which this leadership style is exercised. Further, retaining new employees by providing them good work trends is an art of transformational leaders (Eberly *et al.*, 2017).

4.3 Study limitations and future research directions

The existing research has a few limitations that need to be gauged for future research. First, data collection was cross-sectional for all the constructs, limiting the causal implications, and it was also not possible to completely remove the common bias-variance. For more reliable and substantial results, the longitudinal and experimental design will give better results in future research. The second restraint of the study is data collection limitation from employees working in the organizations of two twin cities, i.e. Islamabad and Rawalpindi. In the future, the scholar should replicate this study by changing the samples and get data from various organizations in different cultural settings for further generalizability of results. Third, the current research evaluated the effect of TL as a whole in predicting overall JED. But in the future, the study should estimate the effect of distinct dimensions of

TL on separate dimensions of JED (fit, link and sacrifice). Moreover, we scrutinized the moderating effect of JC amongst TL and JED, but some other work factors considered by (Chan *et al.*, 2019) as precursors of "on-the-job embeddedness" and found significant results can be used. In the future study, such as level of control over job hours and felt obligation in TL and JED's connection to provide more exhaustive results.

4.4 Conclusion

This study proposed that job design with strong characteristics may help for talent retention in the organizations. It also highlights how transformational leadership, along with a strong manifestation of job characteristics, plays a critical role in promoting employees' job embeddedness. This study highlights that transformational leadership and job characteristics have a strong link with job embeddedness that can motivate employees to stay with the organization for a long time to achieve their stated targets. Thus, this research improves our understanding of how enriched job characteristics are crucial for employees' retention and leadership impact.

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Appendix

Table A1.
Demographics

Demographic Variables	Frequency	(%)
Industry Type		
Banking	32	9.4
Education	202	59
Pharmaceuticals	108	31.6
Gender		
Male	193	56.4
Female	149	43.6
Age of Respondent		
20 – 30 years	256	77.8
30 – 40 years	57	16.6
More than 40 years	19	5.6
Qualification		
Graduation	105	31
Masters	111	32
M.Phil	100	29
PhD	13	4
Others	13	4
Total working experience		
1 to 5 years	198	58
5 to 8 years	80	23
8 to 10 years	38	11
More than 10 years	26	8

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